

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

TULIP SEASON ARRIVES

People walk past tulips on North Michigan Avenue in Chicago after rain passed through the area Sunday. Afternoon egg hunts and the Cubs game were interrupted by a bout of heavy rain across the region. Temperatures might warm up to 70 with intermittent showers midweek after the remnants of a storm system bring wind gusts across the Chicago area Monday, National Weather Service forecasters said.

More weather on Page 10

UPCOMING FORECAST

Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday
High 57 Low 41	High 69 Low 53	High 73 Low 54	High 76 Low 56

Amenities may be key to new office leases

Deals picking up for landlords that refresh furnishings, add cafes

By Brian J. Rogal
Chicago Tribune

Neil Schneider and his co-workers at architectural firm HOK are already enjoying the 11th floor cafe and gathering spaces at One Prudential Plaza in the East Loop and look forward to using a revamped outdoor amenity deck by summer.

“People can go down there with their lunch, enjoy it and not feel they have to be in the office all day,” he said.

HOK just opened the new office at 130 E. Randolph St., an upgrade from its old Central Loop location, said Schneider, the firm’s interior design director.

The 14th floor office, designed by HOK, offers views of Grant Park, high-tech conference rooms, and a cafe and lobby. The property owner has committed to spending \$50 million on building improvements, including adding a pickleball court, sauna and a plunge pool for cooling off in the 11th floor fitness facility.

“I’m excited for the plunge pool,” Schneider said.



People work at HOK on April 10. The firm just opened its new East Loop office. **AUDREY RICHARDSON/TRIBUNE**

Not every office worker will have the opportunity to enjoy the full spas, rooftop decks and pools provided in buildings such as One Prudential Plaza. Vacancy rates in Chicago and suburban office complexes remain sky-high, and

many building owners still struggle with heavy debt loads and face possible foreclosure.

But five years after COVID shuttered the market, companies have begun signing new leases at a faster pace, many seeking

upgrades, either in more modern buildings with better facilities, or locations closer to train lines and riverfront attractions. Some landlords are also pouring money

Turn to Office, Page 2

Policy on traffic stops in works

CPD grappling with ‘nuanced space’ of driver pull-overs in high-crime zones

By Sam Charles
Chicago Tribune

Brian Ramson, one of the district councilors for the Chicago Police Department’s Harrison District on the West Side, moved to Chicago in 2013. Since then, he said, he’s been pulled over by police roughly 50 times — about four of those coming after he was sworn in less than two years ago.

A search of Cook County court records suggests Ramson — a physicist at Fermilab who is Black — has never been issued a ticket, let alone arrested.

And he may not be alone. Law enforcement officials are quick to note the thousands of guns recovered by Chicago police officers during traffic stops each year, but civil rights activists and residents of predominantly Black and Latino communities have long called the Police Department’s traffic stops pretextual — using possible minor violations as a means to try to uncover more serious criminal activity.

“What I’ve seen from police officers in my district is they use traffic stops as a way of going around some of the limitations that they’re finding and trying to enforce drug laws,” Ramson said.

Last week, Ramson was the first speaker during the fifth and final listening session to solicit feedback for the Police Department’s forthcoming general order related to traffic stops. CPD within days will submit the first draft of the new general order that will likely change the rules governing when police officers are permitted to pull over a motorist.

As he spoke, Ramson urged two members of the Community Commission for Public Safety and Accountability to “really approach the situation with ... the perspective that emphasizes the people who have the, I guess, the quietest voices.”

Police Superintendent Larry Snelling often calls for officers to receive “the best” training and be accountable when they don’t adhere to department standards. In an interview with the Tribune last year, he said that any changes to CPD policy must consider the

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INSIDE

Chicagoans welcome return of cherry blossoms

After a few years of underwhelming results, Chicago’s cherry blossoms are back in bloom, and people from across the region flocked to Jackson Park over the weekend to see them. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

‘Professional failures’ in killings of medics in Gaza

An Israeli investigation into the killings of 15 Palestinian medics last month in Gaza by Israeli forces said Sunday that it found a chain of “professional failures,” and a deputy commander has been fired. **Nation & World**

\$4.00 city and suburbs
and elsewhere
177th year No. 111
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Van Hollen helps fill void for Democrats

Party attempts to counter series of policies by Trump

By Steve Peoples
Associated Press

NEW YORK — Now, it’s Sen. Chris Van Hollen’s turn.

The mild-mannered Maryland senator has emerged as a leading figure in the resistance to President Donald Trump’s norm-busting presidency, becoming the latest in a small but growing collection of Democratic officials testing



Sen. Chris Van Hollen, D-Md., speaks to the media Wednesday in La Libertad, El Salvador. **SALVADOR MELENDEZ/AP**

the strength of their political power in a weakened party with no clear leader.

Van Hollen’s rise follows his decision to travel 2,000 miles to El Salvador last week to meet with Kilmar Abrego Garcia, who was wrongly deported and federal courts have said should be returned.

Turn to Nation, Page 4

Illinois lawmakers move to ‘be a check’ on Trump

Democrats consider range of measures in legislative session

By Jeremy Gerner
Chicago Tribune

Almost immediately after President Donald Trump was elected to a second term in November, Illinois Democrats began stressing the need to provide legislative protections against potential action by the White House on issues such as immigration and abortion.

“We’re going to be a check on Donald Trump. As a state, we have rights. And we did it in his first term and we’ll do it again,” House Speaker Emanuel “Chris” Welch, a Democrat

from Hillside, said shortly after the election. “But now that he’s been reelected to a second term as president, there’s a lot of conversations that are happening. A ton.”

With six weeks left in the spring legislative session, lawmakers have a range of measures before them that backers say are necessary to protect Illinois’ progressive policies.

The proposals from Democrats who control both chambers of the legislature include financial regulation and workplace protections as well as enhancements to abortion rights and immigration policy. Republican lawmakers have

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